

*read a book that advocates working four hours a week. And to make matters worse, Jim's clients are not supported well and Mike has to take up the slack; yet every Friday, like clockwork, Jim is there to get his 50/50 cut.*

*When Mike brings this to Jim's attention, Jim gets defensive, and tensions mount. This confrontation only decreases Jim's productivity to where he sometimes doesn't have new clients for months. Mike tries to dissolve the partnership, and Jim resists. Why shouldn't he? He's collecting 50% profits off of Mike's efforts. Mike ultimately has to hire a lawyer and seek a legal remedy. A few years later, the partnership is dissolved and, along with it, Mike and Jim's friendship.*

Partnerships are marriages. After the love affair and the lust wears off, they must survive on character, synergy, and complementary attributes. My early entrepreneurial ventures were all partnerships, and all miserable failures. Not that my partners were bad people, but our work ethics, values, and visions were not compatible. I remember one partner had a normal 9-5 job and was active in intramural sports; the business was number four or five on his priority list. The other partner was out working four other businesses, including ours. That left my business and me, which was priority *numero uno*. Do you see an issue here?

Search the Fastlane Forum for “partnership” and you'll find a garden of complaints about partnerships gone bad. One partner wants to expand, the other wants to brand. One partner wants to advertise, the other wants to develop. One partner wants the expensive cars and the money yet arrives at the office late and leaves early. Partnerships are like marriage—half the time they will fail because the partners just aren't compatible.

“They” say you should partner with people who have complementary skills to you. If I'm a marketing guy, I should partner with a technical guy. If you're a sales-and-people guy, you should partner with an analytical guy. While this is a great starting point to find a partner, it's like marrying the first person you date simply because they have big boobs or look like Brad Pitt. Many other personality characteristics will make or break a partnership.

- Do you have the same work ethic? Will your partner skate while you burn the midnight oil?
- Do you have the same vision? Or will they compete with each other?
- Do you want to grow slowly while your partner wants to own the world and do it fast?
- Do you want to sell franchises while your partner just wants one unit that pays the bills?
- Do you trust this person with your life?
- Do you have the same personality type?